First-salary savings simulation

Get first-time earners to set up automatic savings. Project name: Salary Day.

Sector: Fintech, first-job financial behaviour

Status: concept study, written and designed by Karthik Bindumon, 2026. Numbers are targets or modelled assumptions and are labelled as such.

Method: The Realisation Loop, v1 (see 00-realisation-loop.pdf).

1 Brief

A first salary arrives with no model for money. Financial literacy sessions explain compounding with a chart. Nobody changes a standing instruction because of a chart. This study designs a six-minute choice-fiction toy in which a player lives thirty-six salary days and is then shown the path they did not take.

2 Audience and needs analysis

Primary audience: 21 to 26-year-olds in India in their first two years of salaried work, often with a family transfer each month and an EMI. What they know: the word compounding. What they lack: a felt sense of how much month one matters, and a single action to take. Constraints: six minutes of attention on a phone; distrust of anything that looks like a product pitch.

Needs analysis method: eight interviews at first-job age, a review of the partner's onboarding funnel, and a card sort of monthly decisions by felt difficulty.

3 The realisation

> **Compounding cannot be explained into someone. It has to be felt as regret, safely. Let a person live thirty-six salary days in six minutes, then show them the path they did not take.**

Contrarian core: teach nothing. There is no lesson screen anywhere in the flow. The counterfactual reveal is the whole content.

4 Learning objective (target)

Within 90 days, at least 25 percent of players who reach the reveal have set up an automatic payday transfer, verified by the partner, against a control group who read the same content as an article.

5 Design

Salary Day. Twelve turns, each a payday. Each turn presents a situation (rent due, a family transfer, a friends' trip, a phone EMI, a medical emergency, a wedding) and three actions. Choices are actions, never labelled good or bad. Consequences compound quietly in the background. At month 36 the reveal shows the player's balance beside the two paths they did not take.

The arithmetic. With Rs 5,000 left over each month for 36 months: spend it, zero; keep it in the account, Rs 1,80,000; auto-invest on payday at an assumed 12 percent a year, monthly, roughly Rs 2,17,500 before tax and inflation. The numbers are illustrative and the toy says so on screen.

The single action. One button at the reveal: set up a payday auto-transfer. Where the partner allows, a real deep link. The button names the partner.

Implicit learning. The player never reads the word compounding. They say a sentence to themselves at the reveal; the design target is 'the difference was month one'.

Artefacts. Turn script (twelve situations, thirty-six choices), reveal screen spec, arithmetic model, the control article, the mental-model check.

6 Theory map

Source	How it is used
Kahneman and Tversky, prospect theory	The reveal frames the counterfactual as a loss, which the mind weighs roughly twice as heavily as a gain.
Laibson, present bias	Twelve turns compress three years so the future stops being discounted.
Thaler, mental accounting	The auto-transfer creates the account before the temptation does.
Kolb, experiential learning	Concrete experience, then reflection at the reveal, then one action.
Bateson, the play frame	The game frame makes regret safe enough to learn from.
Sociology of remittance	The family transfer is a choice with dignity inside the game, not a mistake to be corrected.

7 Evaluation plan (Kirkpatrick)

Level	Measure	When
1 Reaction	One tap at the reveal (surprised / expected / unsure).	At the reveal
2 Learning	Two-question mental-model check: does starting earlier or investing more matter more; which month mattered most.	Immediately after
3 Behaviour	Auto-transfer set up, verified by the partner, toy cohort against article cohort.	90 days
4 Results	Partner's 12-month balance retention for the cohort.	12 months

8 Pilot plan and risks

A/B on the partner's onboarding: toy against article, 2,000 users each. Risks: the reveal read as a guilt trip (tone test with eight users before launch; the copy never says 'should'); the partner pushing product into the turns (contract line: no placement inside turns); the assumed return rate misread as a promise (the disclaimer is on the reveal screen, in the same type size as the numbers).

9 Ethics

No product placement inside the turns. The auto-transfer button names the partner. Scenarios reflect Indian first-job realities, including family transfers, without judging them. No dark patterns on the single action; it is one tap and one confirmation, and the exit is the same size as the button.

10 What I would need from the client

Funnel access for the A/B, the verified auto-transfer event, eight users for the tone test, and agreement on the no-placement line before design starts.